Rippling Reflections

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Mature

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Graphic Depictions Of Violence, Major Character Death

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F/F, F/M, M/M

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra)

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by Faded_Glory

Summary

(A companion piece for Tapestry of Time) Adora has finally gave up on Catra. She is focused solely on saving Etheria now. Whatever happens to her ex-best friend now is not her concern. While Catra is consumed by her ambition, to become powerful, to lead the Horde to victory at all cost. Glimmer ascends to the throne of Bright Moon. Taking on the full responsibility of leading the Princess Alliance.

Notes

Finally got this part finished and good enough to post. Still working on Secrets, will post another chapter soon. Until then enjoy this update.

The beginning of what remains

S4E1:The Coronation

Glimmer

In the days that followed the portal. Glimmer wandered aimlessly, through the halls of Bright Moon Castle. Becoming a little more than a ghost, haunting her own home. She shuffled at a slow, steady pace, all hours of the night or day. Brushing her hands reverently over the murals.

Lost and adrift, in her memories…slowly being crushed by the guilt over how terribly she had treated her mother…not knowing that their last fight would be their final moments together. Her gaze dull and clouded with unspeakable grief…a grim, solitary thought spinning round and round. Plaguing her like an omen.

Her father was long dead…

Her mother was now gone…forever…

She was alone now.

Alone…

She was now the Queen of Bright Moon…

She wasn't ready…

She had never in her life been so scared…so unprepared…

The weight of the war now rested solely on her shoulders.

Etheria would rise or fall due to her choices…

So much pressure…

So much responsibility…

She felt so heavy…

Glimmer sluggishly pulled her palm away from the mural of her mother and father in the War Room. Curling her fingers into a fist and pressing her hand against her chest.

It had been a week perhaps more, since her mother sacrificed herself and the unbearable ache there never eased…Lavender eyes shimmering with unshed tears. The tears hung in the corner of her eyes, refusing to fall. As she cast her mournful gaze down in shame.

She was so tired…light headed and dizzy…she hadn't been recharging…she couldn't…her reserves of magic had dried up days ago.

She felt so empty…in every way…

With a painful moan, she turned towards the huge, stained glass windows that faced the Moon Stone dais.

The sight of her birthright was so painful…her throat clenched and swallowing hurt, it felt like shards of glass slicing her insides. She couldn't breathe…her chest felt too tight…

Rushing out of the War Room. Unable to face her Rune Stone… terrified of the duty that lay ahead for her. Accepting the full power of the Moon Stone was accepting her mother's death…she couldn't do it…she just wasn't ready.

Catra

Her gaze fell once more upon her murky, distorted reflection in the mirror. The smooth surface was covered in moisture. From her extended time, under the cold spray from her shower. She stood hunched over, gripping the sides of the metal sink in her small, spartan bathroom. Her Force Captain's quarters had its own private bathroom. It was a small luxury she had been granted with her promotion. No longer having to share a bathroom with her Squad mates back in the barracks. It had been nice…being alone…for once. Not having to deal with the loud echo of slamming doors in the shared locker room down the hall from the showers, or the cold chill of open shower stalls.

Forced to endure the rowdy meals in the mess, with hundreds of other cadets crowding around her. That made her tense and anxious. The shouting and raucous laughter and clattering their trays on the metal tables. That always hurts her sensitive ears, giving her a headache.

Struggling to sleep without Adora…after she abandoned her. Laying up at night, listening to the weird moans Lonnie made in her sleep, or Atila's buzzsaw snoring or the noxious smell of sweat and farts from her annoying bunk mates.

It had been years since she had more than a brief interaction with her old squad.

They had all been reassigned to other strike teams, after her promotion to second in command.

She had barely thought about them over the years...she definitely, 'didn't miss them'. Rubbing her palm into her chest, as a sudden ache grew there as memories of her childhood surfaced unconsciously. Sweet memories washing over her. As she lost herself to the nostalgic reveries of her childhood.

Cuddling with Adora and Tama under their blanket during the cold season. Listening to the Fox Hybrid's bedtime stories. Doing laps

in the back training yard with their entire squad in the warm season, watching as the dawn sky warmed upon the rising of the Day Moon. Teasing Kyle, stealing ration bars and sharing them with Adora in one of her many secret dens growing up. Fighting with her Strike Team in daily sim's. The taste of freedom, when their drill sergeant took them beyond the fortress, for survival training. Camping in the desolation, laughing and fooling around with her squad around a fire. Long nights, huddling in the cold with Adora while on watch duty as teens out on the outer ramparts. Talking about everything and anything, as they patrolled the wall, waiting for dawn…

Catra sniffled as tears fell silently down her cheeks, dripping from her chin into the sink beneath her.

Her circle had narrowed in the last two years, she wasn't forced to share space with another person unless she wanted to. She only had to put up with Scorpia and Entrapta….

Catra cringed and gnashed her teeth. Claws curling into the metal with a brittle scratching sound. Refusing to delve too deeply into her memories of the tech princess. Avidly denying anything good or kind had ever transpired between them in the last two and half years. She had been nothing but a pain in her ass…she was nothing…she had betrayed her first! Getting all buddy-buddy with Hordak. Sending her to the Crimson Waste to die! Saved me, my ass!

Entrapta was never her friend, she deserved what she got. She was going to ruin everything. She had to do it…she had no choice but to get rid of her…to make sure her place at Hordak's side wasn't threatened.

Catra shivered, her damp fur had grown cold.

Since leaving the shower.

She has been having more of those lately.

Never feeling clean…

Scorpia was being weird…she wasn't the same…nervous and uptight around her. But Catra was certain that things would go back to normal soon. The whole confrontation with Entrapta had been intense…she had scared Scorpia for sure. Said some harsh stuff, threatened her. But she had needed to put Scorpia in her place, she was her Commander! Scorpia needed to just deal and get over it. Things would be ok between them soon…or they wouldn't…what did she care.

Catra stood before the mirror, nude and tail swaying in agitation as the fog lifted from the mirror and the room began to dry out. Her reflection cleared up and her gaze fell upon her silver tufts. Grinding the palms of her hands into her eyes angrily and wiping away the moisture, clearing away the tear tracks. Her mismatched eyes narrowed in displeasure. She had always disliked them, they didn't match the rest of her dark brunette mane. They stood out, garishly on either side of her face. Their existence was an imperfection. A genetic mistake...she needed to be rid of.

Shadow Weaver had always liked to comb her fingers through them…in those rare moments she wished to show affection… which had just been another form of manipulation…

No more mistakes!

No more weakness!

(Caring about people got me in this mess.)

From deep within, she felt the rage stir. Feeding upon the anguish of never feeling like she was worthy…redirecting towards the imperfection of her appearance. The disgust she felt for herself. Those tufts…were ugly…they were the symbol of her greatest weakness. As the rage arose, so did her commitment.

She would never be weak again…

Catra unsheathed her claws and with a raw, anguished yowl of heartache. She grabbed one tuft at a time and sliced them off at

the base. Tossing the fur violently into the basin, revolted by its existence.

It was a metaphorical act…of freeing herself from her past.

Catra was methodical about dressing in her new uniform. One, she had designed herself to reflect her coming domination…she was done being subservient to Hordak. The portal had taught her well…she was going to take the power for herself and she was going to make everyone pay!

This uniform suited her better. It was a rebirth, a recreation of who she really was…focusing on her own ambitions, her own personal power. Leaving that weak, pathetic, worthless girl in the past.

Thanks to Entrapta, she knew Hordak's weakness and she would pounce upon it, just like she did to Shadow Weaver. She would become fearless, no one was going to hold her back any longer. She would defy the odds as she always had…she was cunning and she was ruthless and that was her true power. He would see her as an equal…or he could die upon her claws. In the end she would hold all the power.

By the end of this day, she would be the one running the Horde.

Then she would finally have everything she wanted, everything she needed to conquer Etheria.

S4E2:Valley of the Lost

Glimmer

She had been trapped on the throne for most of the day. Taking one Court appointment after another from the royal retainer's of Bright Moon's many fiefdoms. These puffed up peacocks were paraded down the open throne room. In the company of her royal guards to her dais. Where they would present the crown with their nobles, yearly tithing, then follow up with lengthy petitions. The fiefdom might require more protection in the form of soldier's, or in need of road repairs, help with maintaining village resources or even food stores. If their village had gone through a bad drought or flooding in the course of the year.

She came to understand the complex bureaucracy her mother had to deal with.

Also it was soooo slow and it was sooo very tedious and it was soooo boring…

Glimmer never had to sit still for so long in her entire life! She was now slumped in the throne, chin braced in a palm as she rested her elbow on the smooth golden arm of the throne. Her eyes were glazed, as she vaguely listened to a rail thin clerk. Whose features were rather rat like, with his huge front teeth and slightly squinty, round eyes hidden behind thick spectacles. That he kept pushing up the bridge of his nose every few sentences. As he prattled on and on….His voice long having become a monotone drone she wasn't even listening to anymore.

Her thoughts wandered bitterly, how she wanted to be with Bow and Adora on their mission in the Crimson Waste. Desperately wanting her mother back, so she could return to her life as it once was. Where she was just a General, able to fight on the front lines of this war. Craving the adventure and thrill of battle, the satisfaction of pushing the Horde back. Yet she was here. Being a responsible ruler instead…it was infuriating having to stay behind. Knowing that her friends could be in danger and she wasn't there to teleport them away to safety. But that's what her mother had done, delegate and command. Stay behind and keep the kingdom running. She wanted to be as good of a Queen as her mom. So

she sat, fuming in her seat, desperate to retain anything that dullard was saying.

Bow

Adora had been unusually quiet, since their mission to the Crimson Waste. Scratch that, Adora had been acting odd since Glimmer's Coronation…over eager to please the new Queen. Always taking on more duties around the castle and extra missions. So she was gone most of the time.. Never in Bright Moon for very long.

Now that she was stuck inside the walls of the Castle, with the cold season blowing in with daily rain storms once again. She was growing more distant…always pacing the ramparts or lurking in the training yards like a grim shadow. Watching the soldier's combat practice but not joining in like she once did.

Bow kept a close eye on her, knowing from experience that pushing Adora to open up when she wasn't ready only led to her going on the defensive. She would close herself off, brood and become monosyllabic. Or put on a front, with that fake bright smile of hers that never reached her eyes. Repeating that incessant mantra, that she was fine..that everything was good and nothing was bothering her. The most disconcerting thing about Adora this time was. She wasn't avoiding what was bothering her, by punching out her feelings like she usually did. She was like a ghost simply wandering the halls of the Castle. Eyes distant, reflecting on so many unspoken worries. The burden she carried alone, weighing so heavily upon her. Her shoulders bowed and her boots shuffled during her aimless wanderings.

The She-Ra, stuff he knew about. She was frustrated and disillusioned since the portal. But there was more going on… something was eating her up inside.

So Bow waited in the wings. Always prepared to offer support and warm hugs if and when she felt ready to share. Thing was…it had been over two years and Adora had yet to really open up to him about her past in the Horde. Even though he knew it still tortured her.

He just wished he could help…

S4E3:Flutterina

Catra

"Why did you do it!" *Adora's anger and disappointment echoed inside of her as she was sucked into the vortex of portal energies. Catra awoke screaming and gasped in absolute terror. This wasn't the first nightmare of its kind to torment her since the portal. But the lingering fear and loathing that curled like a poisonous miasma inside her heart…hurt. The sudden wakefulness was jarring, she was unsettled and every nerve in her arms and legs were tingling. As the adrenaline coursed through her muscles, the chemical slowly dissipating. She was barely coherent when a concerned twittering vibrated near her ear. With a sudden cry of alarm she leaped back. Growling in embarrassment and seething rage, at finding Entrapta's stupid pet robot had invaded her private room. Catching her in such a vulnerable moment. She knew she had locked her door last night, dammit!*

"Stay away from me!" Catra howled, lashing out with her claws and striking the bot across the face plate savagely.

Emily staggered backward, shimmying back and forth in shock. Nervous, scared beeps insured from its trembling hull, before it promptly skittered out of her room on its stilted legs as fast as it could go.

Catra watched it run off, blinking and glaring as the bot retreated from her room.

That nosey bot got what it deserved, how dare it just invade her privacy like this?

Her secret mission had gone off perfectly, she should be happy. Instead she was brooding up on one of the uppermost platforms near the Forge. She could see their old platform hideaway further south from this vantage point. She never went there anymore, hadn't in over a year. Gnashing her teeth, she ripped her gaze away from the painful sight.

Glaring out at the violent red sky as dusk set in over the Fright Zone. The Horde's war machine was at full power right now, the munition factories, the Forge and the refinery all belching so much chemical haze into the air. That the sky had turned this raicid, glowing red at dawn and dusk. Everything was going to plan, everything she had been working on would be coming to fruition in only a few more months. Then…then, everything she had done, everything she sacrificed would be worth it…

Her guts ached, she barely ate, rarely slept…

She should be happy….but all she was, was angry and now…now she felt like crying.

When Adora fell into her trap, she felt superior, as it was so easy to outwit that bleeding heart! Gloating at her victory up upon the walkway over the courtyard. As She-Ra glared furiously.

"**Hey, Adora. Took you long enough to show up. "** Catra called, acting bored, bracing her cheek in her hand. Smirking, with satisfaction down at her trapped, ex-best friend. Her heart was racing and her stomach was roiling anxiously. This was the first time she had to confront Adora since the Portal.

"**Catra….”** Adora growled, looking up and narrowing her eyes in disdain at the sight of her.

Catra caught the cold, fury in her eyes and it scared her…it was the same hateful look Adora had given her after the Portal…

"**Seriously, I thought I'd have to kidnap another town to get your attention.”** Catra poked, insinuating how self absorbed and arrogant she felt Adora was now that she was She-Ra. " **That's right you were having a party! Must have thought you were pretty special.”** Catra finished, in a resentful growl. Her fear and heartache, drowned out by her rage. Eyes narrowing scornfully, as she confronted Adora.

"**Can we skip the speech, I'm done playing your games Catra. Too many people got hurt when you set off that portal.”** Adora countered, refusing to allow Catra to get to her.

Catra gasped, then growled. Pulling back from the railing, as if Adora's words had been a physical strike.

"**I hope it was worth it. Because I won't let you hurt my friends, or anyone else ever again.”** Adora promised, her eyes were fierce…completely devoid of remorse over what she was about to do. She would do what she needed to, to beat Catra. There was nothing between them any longer…not even sympathy…she was the enemy now.

Catra felt like throwing up…she couldn't stand how coldly Adora was looking at her.

Instead she threw back and head and began to laugh ... .falling back into the familiar spiteful smugness, resolved to put Adora in her place. "**You were the one who left the villager's unprotected. You're good enough at hurting your friends without my help.”** Catra snapped, poking Adora right back where it would hurt her the most. " **But you are still terrible at spotting traps.”** She cooed, with dark amusement.

Adora gasped, as red lightning engulfed her and Swift Wind. Electrocuting them both and sending them to their knees and agony.

It had all gone sideways after that…that had been the plan…but still. She-Ra had honestly tried to hurt her…perhaps…kill her…She had barely evaded the magic that sliced through the bridge she had been standing on.

Catra raised her knee and rested an arm across it, clenching her hand into a fist. As the turbulent emotions of guilt, hate, sorrow and heartache warred inside of her. Adora hated her…wanted her gone…it was certain now…there was nothing left between them.

But this is what she wanted…right? She didn't need Adora…she didn't need anyone…all that mattered was winning…proving to everyone that she was the best, that she was the strongest…

"Catra, there you are." Scorpia's worried voice called out to her from further down the platform.

The sound of Scorpia's concern fueled the inferno of her rage and she lashed out. Hating how weak she felt, how easily Scorpia could see she was hurting and wanted to care for her. Redirecting her pain and her heartbreak upon the poor Scorpioni, in a fit of scathing half-truths. Wanting to hurt her, break her heart just like her heart had been broken. Releasing the toxic poison from inside of her, upon the only friend she had left.

"Where not friends!" Catra spat furiously, looming over Scorpia at the very edge of the platform. The sky was a wash in vivid red, the chemical haze accenting the felines barely restrained rage. The blood red backdrop makes her scowling face, looming over the startled Scorpion even more threatening.

In the last few months, Scorpia had become so clingy and obsessive about their so-called 'Friendship'. Reminding her daily how they were such good friends, trying to console her…like now! She needed to focus on actually doing her job and stop trying to take care of her. She didn't need it, didn't want it! Badgering her incessantly about Entrapta and reminding her of how good it was when Entrapta was around! That she was borderline stalking her now and it was so infuriating! She didn't want to be around anybody! She wanted to be alone! Why can't she just….leave her alone!

Scorpia

Scorpia sat stunned for a moment, absorbing all the venom now spitting from Catra towards her. She had finally found the courage to try and find common ground again, seeking to comfort her friend whom she knew was hurting. Knowing from years of experience how messed up Catra was after a confrontation with Adora out in the field. Only to have her concern disregarded and belittled. Catra's words were like a slap in the face, Scorpia took a deep breath and narrowed her eyes in fury for just a moment. Before turning back to watch the last of the crimson light fade from the horizon. As Catra stalked away into the shadows of the tower behind her.

She swallowed her hurt feelings at being rejected yet again. Now starting to wonder for the first time, how pointless her efforts to connect with Catra had been. Catra was so stubborn…and so very, very angry. Her ambition to rise up the ranks of the Horde. Had been twisted into this all consuming vendetta against Adora, to win at all costs. To…to burn down the whole world it seemed.

Entrapta was the first casualty….it scared her how easily Catra could just attack and throw away her friends. She was obviously on guard and more than a little concerned that she would one day turn on her too?

So she needed to get through to her, before she did something even worse. She knew deep down she regretted what she had done to Entrapta. Knew it was eating her up inside. The walls of the officer barracks were thin and her room wasn't too far from Catra's. She had heard the feline crying out and whimpering in her sleep…no doubt plagued by nightmares. Scorpia has endured enough of her own over the years…those incoherent sounds of distress were very familiar.

Scorpia clenched her pincers into the rim of the platform, staring at the slowly darkening sky with determination. She was not going to let Catra's callous cruelty hurt her. She didn't mean what she said. She was just scared and stressed, that's why she was lashing out. There was still hope, Scorpia wasn't willing yet to give up on her. She could get through to her…she'll see how much she needed Scorpia.. Catra would come around…she had a good heart…she really did…Scorpia just had to be patient and loyal and forgiving ... .then they would go to Beast Island and save Entrapta together. Catra just needed to do one good thing…then she could turn her life around and they could all be happy…

Adora

The cool evening breeze billowed the sheer curtains. The thin, nearly translucent fabric rippled and heaved as if breathing. As Adora sat at her desk in the corner, tapping the sharp, metal point of her quill violently against the page in her journal. The rapid jabs became faster and more furious, as she was practically stabbing the page now. Then she screamed, throwing the quill

and standing up. Knocking the journal across the room with her arm before promptly storming out of her room.

She needed to punch something….hard!!!

The journal thumped open into a far corner of the room, near the waterfall. The wind blowing the pages back until it stilled upon an entry dated a few weeks prior.

'I am so angry with her right now…I …can't even see straight! How could she do it! I can't deal with her anymore. All she does is make one bad choice after another. I am done protecting her, done fixing everything she breaks…I refuse to pick up the pieces of her life this time, when she eventually self destructs. She never thinks about the consequences…or how much she hurts other people. She is selfish and stubborn and … reckless…and mean…and her rage is out of control…and I am done…I am so done with her. '

The breeze picked up again, blowing the pages back to another entry several days later.

'I did it! I finally did it…I didn't hold back…I fought Catra with all my strength…as She-Ra…and I hurt her…it was just a scratch on her chin but it felt good…I have to do this…I have to stop her…I can't let her hurt anymore people I care about.'

The breeze once again gusted across the room, flipping the pages to the final entry.

'I was so furious ... .with her…I have endured her hurting me…trying to kill me…that's, that's fine. I'm used to it, but she destroyed Elboron…used innocent villager's as bait…to lure me into a trap. She hurt innocent people today….just to get to me. I think I tried to kill her today…what is wrong with me…I lost control…I can't stand myself!'

Part Two

Chapter Notes

Thank you Pink Storm for you comment and all those who had left Kudos.

S4E4: Pulse

Glimmer

The new queen found herself standing beneath the pale glow of the Moon Stone. Her eyes lost to introspection, as she reviewed the last few days. Staring up at her birthright, uncertain if she was living up her potential. As Shadow Weaver would say. The tides had turned and not in the rebellion's benefit, since her mother's death. So much had happened in such a short period of time. She had to make some hard decisions, ones she wouldn't necessarily have made if they weren't losing the war so horrendously.

She was scared and she was becoming more and more desperate to regain the advantage over the Horde.

She turned her gaze away from the Rune Stone, as the first rays of the Day Moon peeked just above the forested ridgeline of the valley. That Bright Moon was nestled in. Glimmer sighed heavily and closed her eyes for a moment to gather herself. The Horde was encroaching closer every day, taking outposts and villages… within weeks they would be on their doorstep.

Then what!

What were her options…

She needed to become stronger, she had the potential to become powerful…That's what Shadow Weaver said. Right now…she needed the Dark Sorceress to teach her, mold her into someone powerful.

She couldn't doubt herself right now, couldn't feel guilty about putting her trust in someone who in the past had grievously hurt her best friend as a child.

She needed to stay the course, she needed to become as ruthless and uncompromising as the Horde…so she could win. That's what was needed, she would repair her friendship later.

Adora and Bow would understand…she was certain of it.

Slowly she opened her eyes again, the once cobalt sky of predawn, was warming slowly into indigo at the far off edges. Turquoise and soft pinks illuminating the cloud bank that still touched the rolling hills in the distance.

A cool breeze gusted up from the lake below. The season's were changing once more. The cooler nights of the cold season were fading, the morning hours heating up more quickly as a new day began. Soon the fire shades cloaking the leaves would turn green and vibrant once more. The days of heavy rains would ease, along with the bitter, damp cold.

So much change…

The steady pounding of boots drew Glimmer's notice. She quickly snapped her gaze downward over the edge of the golden balcony. Moving to the curved railing, to stare down from the golden dais of the Moon Stone. Finding Adora, dressed in the flimsy tank and shorts she had slept in last night, during their sleep over in Bow's room. Her combat boots pounding down the long bridge that connected the Castle to the Woods. Her powerful stride, swiftly caring her across the lake and disappearing into the tree line. Her morning and evening jogs were a steady routine. Her commitment to her training was admirable and Glimmer wanted to possess the

same iron will and fortitude to excel at her own training that Adora had.

Glimmer heaved a breath, her fingers gripping the pole of her father's staff more tightly. Her reign so far had not gone as well as she had hoped. She was failing as a strategist, failing as a Queen….and failing as a friend. Glimmer swallowed hard, her mother would be so disappointed in her.

The Horde had been gaining ground up in the highlands, their encroachment towards Bright Moon had been slow and insidious over the last few months. Thanks to that hidden outpost they were sending bots out from. Moving steadily like a cancer through the foothills of the barrier mountains and into the Whispering Woods. Destroying rebel camps, setting up outposts in their place. Bots and Horde militia were cropping up out of nowhere it seemed, burning swaths of forests, taking towns and villages along the way. As they slowly closed in on Bright Moon's border's.

It was infuriating how the Horde just seemed to know their plans? Knew where to strike the Rebellion where it would hurt the most. She had been sending her people into one ambush after another and it was so demoralizing! It was as if Catra had figured out some way to track She-Ra. Bow had gotten badly hurt because she didn't have the proper intel to send her people into combat safely. He was still bedridden, as She-Ra's healing could only do so much.

Adora was growing more distant, she acted as if she was fine around her. But she wasn't, she was growing short tempered and easily riled up during strategy meetings in the War Room. She was just frustrated that they were losing this war, just like everyone else.

"Your majesty." Shadow Weaver's inquiry was stern, yet also subservient.

Glimmer turned from watching the now empty tree line. To acknowledge the Sorceress with a polite nod.

“I’m ready for more magic training…lead the way.” Glimmer responded in a clipped, resolute tone. She would have never been able to find the hidden Horde base, without Shadow Weaver. That secret base had been sending out those new kamikaze bots that drilled into the ground and self-destructed. Having enough of a payload to flatten miles of woods at a single blast. She was tired of sitting on the sidelines while her friends fought without her. She had been frightened and desperate to find a way to get the upper hand, stall the Hordes advance. She needed to understand Catra better, so she went to Shadow Weaver for help.

With the dark sorceress guidance, she had used Adroa as bait, drawing Catra’s focus and then had infiltrated the secret Horde outpost herself. It had been an intense battle, without Adora or Bow to reign her in. Glimmer allowed her fury to control her. Years of anger and pain surged out of her. A righteousness took hold over her rational mind and she fought with a savagery she had never been able to unleash. Catra was evil, she needed to be stopped at all cost. It was the only way to save Etheria, to protect her friends. All of this suffering was the magicats fault! She was the mastermind behind the Hordes war machine! She was ordering the raids on the towns and villages in the highlands.

Leaving death and destruction in her wake.

She was killing people…she had killed her mother! She needed to pay for what she had done, she deserved to die. Glimmer had been driven by her rage, her empathy firmly tucked away and silenced as she allowed herself to tap into the full might of her magic. Leaving the feline to die amid the flaming wreckage of her own base.

It was a day later and Glimmer had yet to feel any remorse or guilt at what she had done, she felt redeemed…her mother… avenged. She was now focused on becoming stronger, more capable with her magic.

Glimmer began to descend the spiral stairs from the dais, with Shadow Weaver walking behind her. Hands folded in her lap as

she followed her Queen back towards her garden for more instruction.

S4E5:Protocol

"Of course! It was the wrong slot! I don't know what I expected! Even when you do know everything, you don't tell me anything. You are useless!" Adora exploded, pointing up at Light Hope. So full of frustration and disappointment and rage she couldn't help but lash out. She had been holding all the pent up resentment and rage inside her for years. As soon as she said it, she regretted it. Adora gasped, shame and regret instantly smothering the heat of her anger. "Oh, Light Hope. I'm.."

"I am a hologram. My primary purpose is to train She-Ra. If I am not doing that. Then I have failed. I am sorry Adora…." Light Hope interrupted her attempt to apologize. Her voice was soft, ashamed. As she faded away.

"Wait…" Adora reached for her. She never knew that the Hologram could feel. "Light Hope!....Light Hope?" Adora called out to her, desperate and afraid that she had messed it all up. She had hurt her. She needed to make things right…she needed to fix her mistake. She should have never lost control...like that.

Adora grunted and winced, as the memory resurfaced yet again to haunt her. As she pounded out her frustrations against the punching bag, down in the Soldier's training gym back in Bright Moon. It was the middle of the night and once again she couldn't sleep. The small, cobblestone chamber was illuminated only by wall scones of glowing crystals. Narrow open windows lined the walls, allowing only a sliver of moonlight to fall in broken swathes across the floor. The chamber was simple, with matts lined up against the far wall for practice in hand to hand combat and floor

exercises. A few punching bags, hanging from the wooden beams in the center and a set of weights nearby. Adora had been retreating to this area of the lower keep for years, finding solace in the familiar military surroundings of the soldier's quarter of the castle. But lately, even this place was feeling closed off and rather claustrophobic for her. She couldn't help The restlessness that gripped her in the middle of the night. As her mind just kept spinning round and round, over her lack of progress.

She had been training with Light Hope for years, but she wasn't any better at being She-Ra then when she first started. If she was…then the Horde wouldn't be winning right now!

She was so sick and tired of that Hologram's refusal to give her a straight answer. She had done everything that had been asked of her…she had let go, she had trained by doing…she had been patient and committed to the training…

Why couldn't she know the truth about her heritage, about Mara, about everything she wanted to know. Why did Light Hope still not trust that she was ready…had not proven her worth already?

She was ready! She wanted to…needed to be the She-Ra…who could save the planet, defeat the Horde and bring Peace.

She needed answer's to do that!

Why was Light Hope still keeping secrets!

S4E6:Princess Scorpia

Scorpia

The day had started out so well…

Her morning routine always got her in the right head space to face the problems of the day.

" ***Good morning world, Force Captain Scorpia reporting for duty." She would hop out of bed, chipper and alert. " Wake up check!" Check herself out in the mirror and make sure everything looks good. "Looking sharp, check!" Begin her morning affirmations as she took a deep breath. "Breath in new day…check." Make her bed, feed Emily. "Push down doubts and insecurities…check…"***

As evening descended over the Fright Zone, Scorpia had disappeared into the forgotten tunnels beneath the fortress. Resolute and determined with her future,

she took to the underground tunnels of her old kingdom. That twisted beneath the fortress and out beyond the Stinger Mountain's into the desolation beyond. Her defection from the Horde had been subtle, her presence easily dismissed by the chaos of the military amassing above. Moving in total darkness at times, with only Emily's power core to light the way. As the bot quietly twittered nervously behind her. They were so deep underground, the air was damp and moldy. Cluttered with the rotted remains of her kingdom's once glorious heritage. Moving like a phantom, into the bowels of the Scorpioni colony. Into the subterranean city that had stood for nearly a thousand years since the Forgotten age. Through the long abandoned workshops of the Maker's Hal, the merchant quarter of burnt out shops. Refusing to look as she was passing small multi connected chamber's, dug into the earth, that once housed families. The joy and laughter of the Scorpioni that once lived and thrived underground now forever silenced…by the Horde.

Moving through the ancient passages of her lost people, that she once guided Catra through years ago, before Princess Prom. Her mind kept drifting…kept reminiscing in the past as she navigated through forgotten passages.

"I am brave, strong and loyal and I give great hugs and I am going to be the best friend I can be!"

Their friendship was new then, she had felt hopeful and happy that she had finally made a real friend. Someone who understood her, wanted to be with her, cared about her as much as she cared about them. It hurt her heart, how things had turned out. How brutally Catra seemed to have changed…over the years...or perhaps she had just been deluding herself this entire time. Perhaps Catra had always been mean and selfishly driven. Yet, she knew she hadn't been sleeping, she was stressed and more irritable than ever. The pressure she was under to win this war was immense, she knew that. But that wasn't an excuse for how terrible she had been treating her.

"I'm so close…If I can pull this off…everything… EVERYTHING, will have been worth it." Catra clutched her head, muttering to herself.

As Scorpia stood before her, tea in hand. Concern and empathy, for what she was going through clear on her face. She hated seeing Catra so worn down and stressed, she just wanted to help ease her burdens.

Knowing that her years of loyalty, of kindness and patience would never be valued. Knowing that she had and would hurt people to get her way. Lonnie had tried to get her to understand. How callously Catra was tossing the Horde Soldier's lives away in the Northern outposts. Emily had been the one to make her understand that. By showing her video recording of how they used to be…the Super Pal trio…then how mercilessly Catra had attacked Entrapta and sent her to Beast Island and then threatened her! The poor bot already wore scars of Catra's claws on her face plate. Finally, Scorpia had to concede that Catra's

need for power, her need to win…was the most important thing to her. She couldn't be friends with her any longer, couldn't stomach the lies she told herself. To make Catra' s cruelty more palatable. She had betrayed her, betrayed Entrapta…she would kill Emily to get those recordings. She needed to get as far away from here as possible, she needed to save Emily, she needed to save herself… she needed to save Entrapta…she needed to make things right.

"You broke the recordings!" Catra snarled, tossing the useless broken piece of tech away violently. "I asked you to do one thing! One simple thing and you completely ruined it. But of course you ruined it. Yeah, your Scorpia. That's just what you do!" Catra's scathing tirade, sliced deep into the Scorpioni. Eviscerating her fragile self worth, as she slowly bowed her head. "You couldn't handle Emily, you never know when to shut-up! " Catra paced and ranted, her fury out of control. As her claws were fully unsheathed and the tail was lashing.

Scorpia merely stood there, as always when being berated by her superior's. Taking the verbal lashing and swallowing her embarrassment and her pain, that cut like shards of glass down her throat. She had endured a lot of abuse in her life time, but never knew it could hurt this much…coming from someone who she admired…whom she…loved…

"All you've ever done was get in my way!" Catra turned and slashed towards her, curling her fingers into a first and raising it up threateningly.

"What did I expect! How can you possibly be this useless." She snarled, pupils reduced to tiny, predatory pin pricks.

Scorpia just stood there, eyes downcast as Catra ripped her apart, destroying the last of her hope that she meant something to her, that her friendship mattered. She couldn't speak, could barely breath lest the tears began to fall. She couldn't do this anymore, couldn't delude herself

any longer. Catra may be hurting…but that did not give her the right to hurt others. She was done!

"What!" Catra demanded.

Finally, Scorpia raised her head. The affection she once had for Catra was gone, she had nothing but the truth to offer her.

"You're a bad friend." She stated, then turned and left her there in the hall.

She never saw the surprise and apprehension that crossed the feline's face after she left. Never saw the shadow of guilt and regret pass over her features. The moment of weakness, smothered instantly by her bitter scowl. Before turning her back and marching away to deal with delivering the bad news to Hordak.

Scorpia crossed the desolate, red soil that surrounded the Fortress in the dead of night. Entering the outer growth of the Whispering Woods by dawn. Disappearing into the heavy undergrowth of roots and bushes as the Ancient Trees seemed to reach out and embrace her. Drawing her away from the loneliness and pain of her old life and welcoming her to move ever onward towards Bright Moon.

S4E7:Mer-Mysteries

Glimmer

The angry sky beyond her window, mirrored the turbulent emotion's raging through her. Her reign so far had been an absolute nightmare! The rebellion had been losing ground ever since her coronation.

They were losing!

What was wrong with Adora…she was She-Ra…she was supposed to be Etheria's Champion. She was supposed to save them…she wouldn't be in this mess. If she could count on Adora to actually make a difference…it was all just so frustrating…

She had hoped Catra had been dealt with, that with the Horde's greatest strategist gone. She would finally get the upper hand. But the Horde was still one step ahead, always ready to repel her forces. Their absolute failure to recapture Dryl. Was a testament to how futile their efforts have become.

They had a spy….of course they had a spy! That was the only way that made any sense. As to why she had kept sending her friends into one ambush after another for months.

Glimmer squeezed her eyes shut tight, as her chest clamped in panic. She couldn't continue to put her friends in danger. Bow had gotten hurt…the next time maybe…he would be dead. She hated having to use Adora as bait…She-Ra was the strongest of them all. But she felt so ashamed to use her that way. It wasn't right and it wasn't honorable…but she just didn't know what to do.

The Horde was closing in…so many outposts had been lost… Salineas had been lost.

She couldn't continue to have false hope that they could win as a team. She needed to take care of things herself!

The fear and desperation she felt had been ruling her action's. She didn't want to have to depend on Shadow Weaver for council, but she was the only one who seemed to understand that strain and pressure she was under. She hadn't done anything but help… but she still felt so guilty.

Every time Adora would argue with her, warn her not to trust the Sorceress. Every time she would catch that wounded look cross Adora's face. When she sided with Shadow Weaver, when she took the old woman's council and not her best friends. In dealing with the war effort, in dealing with uncovering the spy…

Shadow Weaver was cunning and self serving, she knew that. Knew that she had hurt Adora…she didn't know the details of her upbringing. But she had seen the emotional scars, and had held her through the night after many nightmares. Brought on by the war…brought on by having that vile woman in the Castle…brought on by the cruel, vindictive confrontations with Catra….

Glimmer groaned, rubbing her fingers into her forehead to try and soothe the ache piercing behind her eyes.

She didn't know what to do…

She had the potential to be the most powerful member of the rebellion…at least that's what Shadow Weaver had told her. Being the daughter of a magical prodigy and an Immortal Being. She was capable of drawing magic that could easily rival that of She-Ra.

They didn't have the time to keep running around in circles interrogating everyone on the off chance they actually found that spy. She needed to take the fight to the source. If she was as powerful as Shadow Weaver claimed then she could easily infiltrate the Fright Zone herself and take out Hordak…make sure Catra stayed dead this time!

"Glimmer…" Adora's plaintive voice invaded her room.

Glimmer gasped and turned to confront the woman, who had become the source of so much strife and confusion in her heart ever since the Portal.

S4E8:Boys Night Out

Bow

"*What are* you talking about. Glimmer doesn't need a weapon. She needs her friends." Bow advised adamantly, beseeching Adora to understand.

"No she doesn't. " Adora countered, hopping down off the railing of the cutter. "But it doesn't matter. I'll fix this. No matter what Glimmer thinks of me." She vowed, walking away to brood at the stern.

Bow watched her go, the finality in her tone was heartbreaking. What had happened back in Bright Moon? He was distracted momentarily by Sea Hawk singing on the other side of the boat to Mermista. He couldn't enjoy the song anymore. Turning away from the cheerful scene, he folded his arms on the railing and stared morosely down at the sparkling, evening sea. His chest was tight and he was so heartbroken.

The Best Friends Squad had fallen apart.

Adora and Glimmer had been fighting for days. The rift between them had been spreading for months. Glimmer had been pulling away little by little ever since Queen Angella's death.

Not confiding in him like she used to. The pressures of being a queen, losing ground to the Horde and now with the fall of Salineas. She was becoming someone he just didn't know anymore. He would have never thought Glimmer was capable of being so ruthless. Her tactics had been growing more and more questionable. Ever since she started listening to Shadow Weaver and not him. She had no qualms about putting Adora in danger, using She-Ra as bait. He knew she had been secretly going out on

missions all by herself. He was honestly scared about asking her what she was up to. The evacuation of the Salinean coast had been rushed, chaotic and heartbreaking. Glimmer had not been acting like herself for months. He had always known there was a dark side to her, but he had been capable of reigning it in…reining her in. But he just didn't know how to repair their friendship if Glimmer and Adora were not willing to try themselves. He was stuck in the middle unwilling to choose a side, but dreading that one day he would have to do just that.

A soft sniffle drew his attention away from the water. Turning, he could just spy the tip of Glimmer's indigo boot peeking out from behind an array of barrels. That was tucked away against the prow of the cutter. With a heavy sigh he sought to console her.

Earlier, he had watched her approach Adora, hopeful that she was going to reach out first and apologize…try and mend things. But Adora had brushed her aside, retreating away as quickly as she could, unwilling to hear her out.

Glimmer had swiftly gotten upset and angry about it and stormed off herself.

"Hey." Bow leaned over the top of the barrel. Finding Glimmer huddled, with her arms wrapped tight around her drawn up knees. That was pressed against her chest.

"Go away." Glimmer grumbled, rubbing her fingers under her eyes to clear away the tears.

"I doubt you want that." Bow offered, with a sympathetic smile. Moving around the barrels to find a seat beside her.

"How would you even know what I want anymore!" Glimmer snarled up at him.

The rage and bitterness laced in her voice, had Bow stopping mid stride around the barrels.

“What?” He turned to her, completely dumbfounded.

“You're never around anymore Bow…I have never felt so alone…” She breathed, sniffling and ducking her head away into her arms.

Bow rushed around the barrel’s then and quickly pulled Glimmer into his arms. As she broke down in heart wrenching sobs. It was true, Glimmer had been training with Shadow Weaver, while he and Adora were constantly away on missions. Then he had been spending day’s inside Mara’s ship, trying to learn how it worked. They had barely spoken to one another in weeks.

“I ruined everything….Bow…she hates me…” Glimmer hiccupped and trembled in his arms. He held her gently, as she cried. “What happened?” Bow offered after a while when she had calmed down.

“I said some mean things…” Glimmer pouted.

Bow sighed, crooking a finger under her chin and forcing her to look up at him.

“Ok….I saw that you were trying to talk to her.” Bow smiled softly. “Were you going to apologize?”

“No…I wanted to talk about what happened, smooth things over. Tell her she did a good job in the last fight. I thought we were getting along again. We were fighting the bad guys, together. We were in sync out there, it had been a long time since we fought so cohesively….you know… like we used to. But I guess she wants nothing to do with me anymore.” Glimmer offered, adjusting herself out Bow’s embrace. Leaning her back against the barrels to stare out over the edge of the railing to the setting Day Moon on the horizon. Watching the last of the light fade away with a heavy heart.

“You have to apologize.” Bow advised, knocking his shoulder against hers.

“I won’t, because I admit it was mean…but I meant every word.” Glimmer admitted stoically.

“What did you say…” Bow asked several quiet minutes later, his curiosity getting the better of him.

Glimmer cut her eyes to him briefly before squaring her shoulders.

“It’s her fault, my mom’s dead. She hasn’t been keeping her promises. She was supposed to defeat the Horde, protect everyone. If she was a better She-Ra then none of this would have happened. It’s her fault the Horde is winning.”

“Glimmer…” Bow gasped, at a complete loss as to what to say after that. But the way Adora was acting made complete sense now.

Catra

The white hot rage was slowly fading away, her vision beginning to clear from the tearful blur. Heaving for breath, she slowly came back to her senses and started to assess the damage around her. Finding herself kneeling on the shredded remains of her bed. The Horde tapestry hanging over her bed frame, was sideways and slashed to ribbons. The metal walls were gouged and her side cabinet lay against a corner dented and twisted. The only item in her room that remained unharmed was Adora’s dark blue blanket. That was currently bunched up in the corner with her pillow.

Catra howled and flopped onto her side, balling up the blanket under her chin and pressing her face into the fabric. Desperate to find any fragment of Adora’s scent for comfort. But tragically, the blanket smelled like her.

She loathed that smell!

Screaming in fury, she tossed the blanket away in disgust and curled up tight. Hugging her knees and rocking back and forth.

Adora was gone….

Adora hated her…

Shadow Weaver was gone…

Shadow Weaver hated her…

Entrapta was gone….

Entrapta hated her…

Scorpia….Scorpia….Scorpia was gone…

No…I can find her…I won't let her leave me!

How dare she leave!

Catra rolled out of bed and ran out of her room, heading up to the surveillance tower to search for her. She had a plan…she…she… she would drag her back to the Fright Zone…lock her up for treason…then…then…no…she needed to find her…needed her… needed her…

She was alone…

Scorpia hated her…

She was alone…

Scorpia hated her..

She was alone…

Part Three

Chapter Notes

Thank you Pink Storm for your comment and all those who have left Kudo's.

S4E9:Hero

It was during those early hours, in the peaceful gray haze just before dawn. After yet another restless night, tossing and turning and unable to settle. Adora would find solace here, practicing in the open courtyard, nestled in the lower bastion's of the Castle. Just to the south of the Gatehouse, in the outer battlements. That the Castle Guards used for weapon's practice.

These simpler, stone halls of the guard's barracks had become like a second home to her over the years. Ever since General Juliet had taken her under her wing. Training her in the sword, mentoring her and ultimately expanding her knowledge of war, of battle tactics and weapon techniques. Giving her purpose beyond that of just being She-Ra. Harnessing not only her physical prowess but sharpening her focus as well. Through endless drills of repetitive actions, that had become as natural as breathing now.

With the comforting weight of her practice sword in her hands. Adora felt grounded. Moving through the many sword kata she had mastered. The steady flow of movement, freeing her mind to wander. As her muscles flexed and stretched through each pattern. Shifting her feet, adjusting her balance…swinging the wooden blade down, raising it over her head…repeating the patterns…back and forth…it soothed her, focused the chaos in her thoughts. Allowed her to work through the maelstrom of her feelings in a more restrained, less destructive manner than taking them out on the sand bags. Which just does not hold up very well

anymore, when She-ra's strength unconsciously seeps into her punches. Whenever she's extremely upset.

Juliet was really not too happy with her, after she sent a punching bag through the wall of the guards weight room, several months back.

Slowly, methodically, the world faded as her focus drew inward.

(*You are distracted by your attachments.*)

Light Hope's voice echoed in the depths of her mind like a reprimand.

The festering guilt she now felt gnawing at her. As all her failures spun in a tempest in her memory. She hurt everyone who she had ever gotten close to. She had left Catra behind…Chosen her destiny…Chosen the Sword over her best friend. Over the one person, who had stood by her for years. Never had any expectations of her, never wanted anymore then she could give. Catra had always looked out for her…and she looked out for her.

Why did she do it?

Adora had thought she was doing the right thing, then. Thought it was the only choice. But it wasn't…was it?

Had even been a choice?

She had been drawn back to the Woods, ever since she touched the hilt. The pull had been so strong…the voices calling to her… the need to find the sword…claim it for herself. She couldn't explain those obsessive thoughts that had taken over her mind then. The need to go alone…to leave Catra behind that night. Upon reflection now, it had gone against every fiber of her being to do that. Her and Catra were a team…they always had been… why would she have done that?

But the pain and suffering of their private war….had rippled out ever since.

Growing in strength every year since.

Has it been worth it?

(*There was one before you, who could not let go.*)

Adora spun in a slow circle, sword held at blocking angle, taking a calming breath as the gloom settled around her. Light Hope had told her that she would make things worse if she left Crystal Castle. She hadn't listened. Regret over her own failures as She-Ra, rippling through her mind.

Angela was gone…

Salineas was destroyed…

They were losing the war…

Glimmer had lost all faith in her..

So many broken promises…

(*She struggled with a power she could not control. Until it became too much for her mind.*)

She had committed herself to Light Hope's training for years! Had given up so much to be the She-Ra, Etheria needed…that Light Hope wanted. She had worked tirelessly towards that greater good but never, ever succeeded at achieving anything.

Worthless…

She had barely been sleeping for the last few weeks, plagued by doubts. All because of what Glimmer had said, the blame she put on her shoulders for her them losing the war, the loss of her mother…everything.

Useless…

(*She was compromised, she gave into fear and faulty reasoning* .)

Mara had gone through the same torment as She-Ra…forced to become the First Ones weapon…being betrayed by Light Hope… Was all of it going to happen again?

Was Etheria on a crash course to destruction…with no way to stop it?

(*Her desperate actions led to devastation.*)

Adora screamed, lurching upright in her bed. Her hand unconsciously patting the mattress at her feet. Seeking comfort from someone who had not been around for many years. Disorientated and slowly coming to realize that all of it. Had been a dream. The stress and anxiety of her real life bleeding into vivid reenactments of her day to day turmoil, inside her unconscious mind. Adora sniffled and curled up, pressing her face into her pillow.

Mara's weapon…the Heart of Etheria…it could destroy the planet… she didn't know how to save everyone from the Horde…

She was scared and overwhelmed and she felt so alone…

She was failing at being She-Ra…failing to be a good friend…all she did was hurt people…she ruined every one of her friend's lives.

S4E10: Fractures

Adora

A five minute break was not going to calm her down. She was furious and well beyond mere frustration with Glimmer. She didn't know her anymore! Shadow Weaver's power hungry influence had crawled inside her best friend like a parasite.

Using the Heart of Etheria…was suicide!

But Glimmer didn't listen to anyone anymore!

She was going to destroy them all!

Adora had retreated out to the open garden's behind the central keep. Stomping along the grass, towards the marble railings. To glare ominously down at the calm, lake shimmering below. The evening sky, darkening into a soft indigo as the Day Moon set behind Sky Dancer Mountain.

She wanted to hit something so bad! She wanted to shake Glimmer senseless, until she listened, until she saw reason. Stopped being a stubborn, insufferable brat! But she just couldn't get through to her!

It was Catra all over again…and the smothering dread now consuming her was sending her into a raw panic.

Shadow Weaver should have never been allowed to stay in the Castle. After all she had shared with Glimmer over the years about how terrible and cruel that woman was. How she had hurt her… growing up.

How could Glimmer trust her…how could she choose Shadow Weaver over her?

She felt so betrayed…it was Catra all over again…how hurt and heartbroken she felt. But it didn't matter…Glimmer made her choice! They weren't friends anymore she would do what she had to. To make sure Etheria was safe.

She hated how scared and furious she was right now. She was losing control of this war and herself. Adora never noticed how

tightly she had been gripping the railing until the sharp crack of shattering stone echoed into the night.

Adora gasped and tucked her hands up against her chest in alarm, to find the railing broken. Chunks of marble crumbling away to tumble to the grass below.

Shadow Weaver

The guest room in Bright Moon Castle, that was once her prison cell. Was small and still rather spartan for her taste. But she never had much of a chance to decorate it, since she had been under guard and never allowed to leave the Castle grounds for the last few years. Until recently, that is. Yet even though she now had the freedom she so craved, decorating was still very low on her priorities.

The room was set at the end of a long hall, in a lower, more ancient tower on the outer bastion's near the shoreline of Half Moon lake. Shadow Weaver had wandered these drafty corridor's that still held the narrow, open window casements from when it was once the Temple of the Sky. Shadow Weaver had been a scholar of Etherian history, First Ones lore and ancient runic magic long before she was a dark sorceress for the Horde. So finding herself tracing the runic knots of the Lunari, framing the solitary window in her room. While deep in thought. Was one of her cherished past times. The tactile meditation grounded her and helped focus her thoughts.

The old woman sighed heavily as she turned from the window. It had been a long day and she wasn't allowed to attend the alliance meeting, so she had retreated to the quiet sanctuary of her room. The only place left on Etheria that she may call home, where wards of her own creation protected her from attack. The halls beyond these four walls were filled with people who loathed and

despised her. Her time beyond these four walls, she had to be alert and on guard.

Even her time in her garden no longer gave her any solace. The garden had served its purpose, providing her with conjuring ingredients to teach her new ward how to use her magic. It was time to move forward once again, the end game was within reach and she was growing rather impatient to finish her mission.

The last couple years, she had been weaving her threads towards her goal. Acting humbled and timid around Angella, who merely tolerated her presence. Far too kind hearted or merely just a coward, unable to kill her as she deserved. Once Angella was lost to the Cross Roads of Worlds. She began scheming her way into Glimmer’s good graces. The overwhelmed and frightened girl was yearning for guidance and she was more than happy to give it.

The final dye had been cast. Glimmer was set on her course towards releasing the Heart of Etheria. Her personal vendetta against the Nameless One will be complete in only a few more days. She needed to prepare to thrust that proverbial dagger right into that malicious creature's heart!

The teardrop shaped light crystals hanging along the corner of her room were glowing dimly. Casting long shadows over the room, as the last of the Day Moon’s light faded. The narrow window carved into the round wall. Allowed the cool evening breeze to infiltrate her sanctum. The window looked out upon the base of the Moon Stone’s golden pillar.

Reminding her everyday how useless her efforts to save the Queen within that portal reality had been…no matter how hard she had focused she just couldn’t control that magical vortex. The wild chaos of Time and Space had devoured her along with everyone else. Perhaps it had been by design? How was she a mere mortal to try and figure out the complex destiny of an Immortal like Skuld.

It was her duty to guide her daughter now, along the right path. At least the path she needed her to thread, so that her plans could come to fruition.

Shadow Weaver glided in the semi darkness away from the window, towards her bed. The room was neat, well cared for. With very little within besides a plush armchair, a bed, a chest of drawers, a looking glass and a desk. The small living quarters and lack of luxury reminded her of her time as an apprentice of the Sorcerers Guild. It was bitter sweet, how her life seemed to come full circle.

A scorned child, abandoned on the streets of Skara. Fighting for survival and the right to live. Only to be saved by Norwyn, who saw potential in her. Left to fight for acceptance, struggling to find her place among her peers in Mystacor. Obtaining power and prestige only to have it taken. Once again left abandoned and struggling for survival until Hordak took her in. Regaining her power and her prestige, only to have it stolen by a child she had raised. She was as proud of Catra, as she was humiliated and resentful of what she had done to her. She had twisted that girl's heart, molded her ambition, her cruelty…ruthlessness…sharpened her into a weapon that she had hoped to wield, not to have it stabbed into her own back. Shadow Weaver's heart ached every time she found herself dwelling upon her tortured past.

That had twisted her into this wretched monster, this vengeful creature.

So many mistakes…so many regrets…

So many to count now, so much to atone for…yet it was all for the greater good…wasn't it?

Her old bones ached, when the temperatures dropped in the evenings. As the hot season once more began to fade. The cool season settles in with the inevitable cold to come. With an exhausted groan she slowly pulled off her mask and set it down

on her desk. Avoiding looking at herself in the mirror as she crossed the room to sit, heavily upon her thin mattress.

It had taken only a few months, after Adora had healed her. For her to get settled and begin her magical experiments again. She couldn't live without magic, desperate and resolved to her inevitable fate. She found her robe was covered in the Kaydak Shard dust. That she had used to teleport herself out of the Fright Zone. It had taken several weeks of toil with a pair of tweezers, but she had managed to extract the dust from the fiber's. Gathering it all into a tiny tin, that had once held sugared fruit from one of her meal's. From then on, she had been adding the dust to her morning tea for the last couple years. Poisoning herself once more with the Nameless Ones essence, just enough to become a magical parasite once again.

Just like with the Black Garnet she needed to recharge everyday. She was able to manipulate the Princess, when she was at her most desperate. When Adora had been captured in the Crimson Waste. So she could finally feed off magic again. Since then, Glimmer had unwittingly become her sustenance, under the guise of her magical training. She had been siphoning away the Queen's limitless power ever since, growing in strength…for the day to come….the day she destroyed the Nameless One for good.

She had been teleporting all over Etheria for the last few months, ever since she had earned Glimmer's trust. After the Queen had taken her guards away, Shadow Weaver was truly free again. Allowing her to roam the castle as she saw fit. She had used that time alone to her advantage to gather what she needed, what she had hidden back in Mystacor. Deep in the bowels of the forgotten halls of Arxia.

Shadow Weaver reached beneath her pillow, pulling out a black velvet pouch. Untying the string and meticulously pulling out a black vial filled with ice blue dust and several glowing shards of crystal. She had been stealing fragments of the Princesses Rune Stones over the last few months. It had been easy, infiltrating their kingdoms while the Alliance was distracted by the chaos

created by the spy Catra had sent. She already had a broken bit of the Black Garnet, from her mask. So she never had to enter the Fright Zone again. Which suited her just fine.

Now she was ready…would be ready, when Glimmer and the others released the magic at the Heart. She would channel that ultimate power through these shards and open a portal to the Timeless Dimension. She would evoke the Primordial Magic of Sanctuary and obliterate that Demon….Gorta, in his own lair.

The less than honorable choices she had made to get to this opportunity to destroy him. Had guaranteed that she would never be seen as a hero…she was at peace with that…She would always do what needed to be done to save Etheria.

It was enough to know she was striving for the Greater Good.

Catra

The days had blurred into an endless parade of pain, rage, loneliness and paranoia. She never slept, didn't eat…She just prowled the corridors of the Fright Zone. Unable or unwilling to curb the intensity of her emotions, the vitriol of her temper, as she screamed order's at every soldier she met. Sending them out again and again to advance forward, to take more outposts, subjugate more villages. That violent tempest fueled by her pride and a sense of superiority.

Yet at the same time she hated how rising up in the ranks of the Horde set her above the rest. How her old squad mates feared her…wanted to get as far away from her as they could...she was alienated and shunned like never before.

She wished to return to the old days, when she was in the barracks. Wanted to so desperately to return to the simpler,

sweeter days. With her squad…running drills, owning the battle sims and making fun of Kyle.

Being a part of a combat unit…again…being a family…

It was lonely at the top…she missed Scorpia.

So she found herself hiding in the surveillance tower searching for that traitor! Sitting before the screen's scanning the camera's, obsessively listening to the chatter on the com's. Her exhausted mind spinning, dry, bloodshot eyes darting, grasping desperately at every tiny detail in the background. Hoping…wishing to find a trace of her.

She didn't care about winning…not really…she just wanted her back.

She didn't want to be alone anymore!

Double Trouble wasn't answering their com's…

She was scared…everything was unraveling…she was losing control…

Everything she had worked for…

Everything she had done…

Everything she had given up…

Everything she had once believed in was pointless.

Nothing made sense anymore…

Everything went white as rage and pain took over… once again…

" *I've taken the last of the coastal towns. What is the status of the Woods* ?"

Hordak's authoritative demand echoed inside the Surveillance tower.

As Catra stood at attention, her smile was tight and far too forced. As she gave her report. " ***Our raiding parties have crushed the villages near our current outpost. Tomorrow we move farther inland. Everything is under control."***

"Excellent. Etheria will be ours yet." Hordak cut the feed to the largest screen.

Catra took a deep breath as she stepped back from the console. The air rattled weakly in her chest as she retreated from the ravaged equipment. Once again alone, she pulled off her mask. Struggling to breathe. Her finger's released the metal armor that once protected her. It clattered to the floor, making a hollow sound. As she finally crumpled under the weight of her misery, falling to her knees. Grasping the sides of her head as she curled up and clenched her teeth. Refusing to cry too loudly, unconsciously concealing her weakness even when she was locked away in the tower.

Utterly and completely alone…

Yet the broken sobs still surged forth and tears streamed down her cheeks. Holding herself tight, she began to rock back and forth as her tail curled protectively around her waist.

She felt so lost…so utterly and completely defeated.

She had no one…no one at all who cared about her.

Part Four

Chapter Notes

> Thank you Pink Storm for your comment and all those who have left Kudo's. This last part took a little extra time to get right. I change fonts a-lot in this one, attempted to separate what is cannon from the show and my little bits of added context that link to my own fic. I hope its not to confusing.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

S4E11: Beast Island

Adora

The eerie chittering of the Pooka echoing all around them. Was an ominous serenade constantly following them. As the pack of predator's herded their prey ever deeper into the island. Always staying out of sight, calling out to each other. Flanking their prey, positioning themselves for another attack.

Panic shot through their limbs, making them run faster, to duck and weave through the maze of the corrupted forest of tech and trees. In a desperate attempt to outrun them. Jolting and changing direction randomly at every crack of a branch overhead. Knowing the monster's were leaped through the canopy. The rustle of their hind claws that scraped the leaf litter that clogged the knots of the roots, twisting all around them. Keeping them on the run.

Adora chased after Swift Wind, as he fled in terror from the pack of monster's trying to kill them. The all consuming fear, confusion and disorientation surging through their sacred bond was quickly overwhelming her. Adrenaline was coursing through her, like

lightning sparking across every muscle. She was hyper vigilant, eyes darting from each and every shadow and any blurred movements caught in her peripheries. As she franticly cut away the webbing vines in her path, with her sword, seeking to catch up to him. Calling his name in some desperate attempt for him to return to her side.

This rescue mission had quickly devolved into a manic race for survival. As the deadly monster's they encountered on the island were far beyond what she could handle as just Adora…She was so out of her depth right now and she couldn't transform…she could barely think straight with that low drone humming in her ears.

She felt so helpless…without She-Ra. She had lost control of this mission and everyone was going to die and it was all her fault!

She was really scared right now and that wasn't helping her at all, either!

"Hang on!" Adora cringed and clasped a hand to her ear, seeking to block out the discordant noise. As she finally caught up to him, finding her beloved Alicorn standing lost and forlorn.

"The signal…you hear it too now don't you ?" Swift Wind whispered, despondently. As the predatory vines crawled up his flanks, "It's so loud…" He whimpered, closing his eyes, starting to succumb to the signal…losing his will to live. "I can't think straight." he whispered, as the vines circled his neck, pulling him down, his weak shaky legs quickly giving out as the vines siphoned away his life.

"No!" Adora cried in anguish. Moving urgently towards him. As he lay on the ground, exhausted and resigned to his fate.

"Swift Wind we have to keep going!" She pleaded, crouching down and starting to pull at the vines, cutting them away. "They are right behind us."

"Can't stay. The signal is too strong!" King Micah declared, his voice sharp and desperate with fear. As he and Bow ran blindly through the eerie labyrinth of corrupted tech and twisted roots of the blackened forest towards them. "The Pooka lured us right into a trap! We have to move!" He urged, eyes full of panic as he glanced at Bow. Who was now clutching his head and groaning in agony as the signal invaded his mind. Quickly falling to his knees, as it became too much for him to bear.

"Bow!" Micah turned back in alarm.

"Bow!" Adora noticed Bow falter and was quick to charge towards him to help. In her panic, she left Swift Wind to be entombed by the vines in seconds. "No, not you too. You have to fight it!" She urged, raising her sword up to cut the vines now pinning the archer down only to have the blade ensnared over her head. As the vines were now quickly converging upon them from all sides.

"It's too late…isn't it." Bow moaned, his eyes staring blankly at the ground. His stare was despondent…his life draining away. "We couldn't fix it." He muttered.

While Adora stared at him in horror, the vines took their opportunity to finally creep around her body now that she wasn't moving.

"No, we can still get out of here." Adora shook her head, beseeching him no to give up. "Micah, help him!" She called, turning to find the King was also caught up in the vines. But he was still thinking clearly, able to reach out and try and rip the vines away from Bow's chest.

"King Micah!" Adora called out in warning, as the vines were quickly latching all over him. He groaned and writhed in their grip, reaching for her instead.

Adora reached back, desperate to free herself…to save everyone!

"Don't give in now!" She grasped his pelted wrist gauntlet tight and pulled.

"Not after all this time. We'll get you back to Bright Moon. Glimmer needs you to come home and help her be Queen and…" She urged him to keep fighting.

"Queen…" Micah's voice was shocked, as the reality of how long he was gone set in…that his beloved wife was dead. "If she's Queen, then that means…" The devastation and sorrow that washed over him was all consuming. Tears welled in his eyes and quickly fell down his bearded cheeks. Adora watched in horror as his heart shattered with grief. Then like a candle being snuffed out, the light faded from his eyes and he allowed the signal and the vines to take him. He released her hand and bowed his head in defeat.

"NO…King Micah…Bow!" Adora cried out in desperation. "Swifty!" She turned back in panic, as all her friends were being slowly entombed by the vines.

"Please I can't do this alone!" She pleaded to them…then cried out in anguish and grief towards the very fabric of the universe itself. "I can't…I can't…do this. " Finally admitting defeat, she allowed the tears to fall. The weight of being She-Ra…that she had been carrying for years crushed her instantly. As she was consumed by her self doubts, her regrets and her guilt.

She was weak…

She was useless…

She was a failure…

She was just so tired…

Adora bowed her head, refusing to fight any longer, she allowed the vines to wrap around her. Lost to her misery, as her very essence was being drained out of her. She crumpled to her knees, as the vines pulled her down, hand still raised above her head, clutching the hilt of her sword. As she hung limp and defeated within the ensnaring vines. "Glimmer was right..." She moaned, staring up at the corrupted ceiling of the forest as the vines entombed her.

The despair and exhaustion that seeped into her was insidious, as the vines curled and tightened around her. Adora hung, limp in the restraining clutch of the dark vines as they held her aloft. Staring up, blankly at the glowing black branches of mutated trees webbing over her head.

She was so very tired…

Of fighting…

Of seeking the approval of others..

Of struggling to be perfect…

Of striving for a victory that would never come…

She felt so lost…so defeated…nothing made sense anymore and she just couldn't do this anymore…

She wasn't good enough…

She wasn't strong enough…

She wasn't smart enough…

She hurt everyone she cared about…and perhaps, it would be better for everyone if she just disappeared…

She just wanted it all to end, she wanted to finally know peace… to be at peace…

As the vines curled over her, sealing her away inside their constricting clutch. Draining her life away, devouring her magic… her soul…She closed her eyes and welcomed the coming darkness of death.

Instead a blinding white light surged and enveloped her. Suddenly her entire being was bathed in warmth, she felt a calm serenity falling over her and pulling her towards something…she hadn't felt in a very long time…

The soft sensation of familiar finger's carding with hers, pulling her onward at a stumbling gate. Bright, cackles of delighted laughter peeling through the stale, recycled air. The sound was so full of amusement and joy, it had her own heart soaring with glee. Then the comforting rumble of her purr, echoed and seeped into her very soul like a balm of pure bliss.

Slowly the world reformed around her, the plain stark halls of the Fright Zone stretched out all around her. As she was racing behind her best friend…they were barely teenager's. Catra held her hand tight, pulling her along the empty corridors. She was just like Adora remembered her, with her wild mane cascading down her back. Her battle mask, framing her face, the rusty metal dented and scratched from wearing it constantly for the last year. Dressed in her old red and white striped tunic and ripped gray shorts. Catra's wide leather belt with the Horde insignia buckle caught Adora's eye as it glinted in the half light of the corridor as dusk was settling over the barracks. When suddenly the overhead lights snapped on with a brilliant cascade of sharp bright yellow radiance and a low annoying hum.

Adora had given her that buckle, when they were promoted to Sophomore Cadets. It placed her as being second in command of their squad. She had been so proud that day. Polishing it up on

her bunk, her purr rumbling through the bunkroom for most of the night.

"Com'on dummy…!" Catra yanked on her arm, snapping her attention back up to her face. Adora grinned sheepishly, a blush heating her cheeks and crawling over her ears, at being caught staring at Catra's crotch of all places. Now focusing on Catra's mismatched eyes, glowing in the inky darkness of the main parade yard. As they ran across the tarmac towards the huge chain link fence that bordered the cadets barracks from the Infantry Sector. The magicat's cocky smirk was amused, eyes full of mischievous intentions. As she led Adora somewhere. They were headed out on some secret adventure that wasn't allowed, or perhaps it was just dangerous.

Either way, Adora was all in!

Adora didn't care…she was with Catra.

Adora's chest swelled with happiness, reveling in the purity of these moments. As they pushed and pulled at each other, rough housing as they went along the shadowy, poorly lit, side streets deeper into the fortress. The roaring sounds of tanks and cargo haulers rumbling down the wider avenues around the was just ambient noise.

Everything was simple again and her world made sense. Where all she had to do was follow Catra, knowing that in the end no matter what, everything would work out. They would make it through together…they always took care of each other. Still so certain that nothing would ever come between them.

In an instant it seemed, they had climbed up to their secret spot, their open platform high above the forge. Adora was breathing hard from the strenuous climb, her lungs adjusting to the thinner air so high above the fortress. Dressed in her Senior Cadet uniform, with her red Squad leader jacket. Sitting with her legs splayed and booted feet pressed together upon the metal floor, leaning her back against the rusted railing. Craning her head up,

finding the night sky above was oddly clear, with the many moon's of Etheria on parade overhead. Adora glanced down with a soft sigh, finding Catra sprawled out on the floor before her. Dressed as she had once known her, before all this mess of Destiny had stolen her away.

Her long brunette mane was fanned out behind her head, her lighter gray tufts streaming down the sides of her face. As her battle mask set aside, laying out of reach upon the floor. She lay with her arms crossed behind her head, eyes closed, as she slept beneath the moonlight. The soft glow, casting her in a gentle silver light. The sight of Catra so at ease beside her, was truly sublime to behold.

Adora sighed, closing her eyes briefly as she smiled contentedly. Basking in the sanctuary of this perfect moment. Before slowly opening her eyes and surveying the surreal landscape beyond the platform. Her breath was taken in awe, at the tranquil beauty that surrounded their secret hiding spot. The drab tower's of the Fright Zone were strangely absent. She could see the rocky peek of Sky Dancer mountain on the horizon instead, the mysterious deep green forest of the Whispering Woods hugging the land below them. A lush valley stretched around them, with a sparkling ribbon of the Singing River winding away out of view. She could just make out the ghostly glow of the monolith, that was the Crystal Castle in the distance. She could taste the salt of the Growling Sea in the air, as a warm breeze picked up. Tossing her loosened hair poof across her forehead.

Adora was quick to reach up and brushed the stray strands of blonde hair out of her eyes and tuck them behind her ear. Her eyes slowly adjusted to the somber light of the moon's overhead. Slowly, returning her gaze down from the heavens.

Her breath was once more taken, as she became enraptured by her best friend. The sharp lines of her features were softened, as she slept. A delicate beauty had taken over her face. Her long lashes fluttered subtly as she dreamed, rounded cheeks glowing with a faint blush. Her freckles dusting her dainty nose and across

her tan cheeks, shimmered like glitter. Catra truly was something magical, she was absolutely gorgeous…ethereal even.

Adora watched the gentle rise and fall of her chest for hours in the moonlight. Noticing the cute twitching of her ears and loose curl of Catra's tail that was wrapped around her wrist. Catra's need to always claim her, had always been subtle. Adora smirked and laughed quietly. So very grateful to be here…to be with her again…like this…unburdened…

"Adora…" Catra called her name in a soft imploring breath.

Adora's instantly refocused her gaze upon the magicat. Finding her awake, having turned to face her, eyes open and full of tears. Never had Adora seen her look so distressed, so very vulnerable…

Adora's heart suddenly clenched in her chest and she felt like crying herself. She moved on instinct to comfort her, crawling over to Catra and settling down at her side. Catra instantly curled up against her chest, as Adora encircled her with her arms. Pulling her in and tight against her. Pressing her face into Catra's thick dark mane, as Catra nuzzled into the crook of her neck. Scent marking her as she began taking a shaky, heaving breath, clutching Adora even tighter. Her claws digging into the heavy material of her jacket across her shoulder blades.

"I've missed this…I've missed you. " Catra whimpered, brokenly. Hiding her face against Adora's neck as she wept brokenly.

"I know…I've missed you too…" Adora's voice warbled with so many intense emotions of loss and regret. Tears streaming down her face as she hides in Catra's thick hair. Joining her long lost best friend in their mourning. As she began to whimper and cry as well.

"How did it go so wrong…" They whispered together, through gasping sobs.

As the world went white.

Flashes of memory, Adora felt the gentle, compassionate press of Queen Angella's lip upon her forehead. She opened her eyes to find herself once more before the raging energies of the portal. With the Queen offering her a final farewell.

"Take care of each other." Adora whispered, as she watched the Queen mouth the very same words over her shoulder before flying off to make the greatest sacrifice for all of them.

Then all the fights she had been having with Glimmer, bombarded her. The pain and regret that their friendship…just like Catra's had gone so very wrong. Followed by all the sweet, tender moments she had shared with her friends within the Princess Alliance…with the Best Friend Squad…

with Bow and Glimmer.

"Glimmer…" Adora whispered, plaintively. Regretting that she had turned away from her. That she had just accepted that their friendship was over and was unwilling to try and fix it. Not wanting to allow Glimmer to continue to hurt her. Unable to put her heart on the line again, unable to trust and unable to forgive.

Just like Catra…

"Don't give up…Adora… **"** Catra's voice called out deep inside her heart.

" Don't give up…on me…" Glimmer's voice echoed just behind.

"You can do this…Adora…believe in yourself…" Another voice whispered, one that was soft, sweet and primordial.

The joy she felt in her tender memories of her friends, the support and hope she found in their presence in her life. The words of encouragement refortifying her were enough for Adora to try

again. This time she reached deep inside herself, towards the very core of her own power. Coming to terms with her own weakness, with her mistakes…that she couldn't control everything and everyone. That she had to let go….she had to allow her friends to make mistakes, to be weak in their own ways. Promising that she would never give up on them, she would reach out when they were ready and she would forgive.

She was stronger than her doubts.

She was stubborn and she was resilient.

She would overcome and she would conquer whatever threatened her…or her friends.

She would take care of them…all.

She wasn't Mara, she wasn't the She-Ra's of the past. She didn't do this to fulfill some destiny. She became She-Ra to help others. Her attachments, her friends, are a part of who she is.

They made her stronger…

Urging the magic from within herself this time. From the core of her own pure heart, pulling that thread to the surface. Her eyes glowed a radiant blue, with a tremendous power. That was now all her own. A fierce scream rents the air of the once silent dark forest. Filled with hope and an unyielding will that she would never give up again, she tore herself free from the vines.

"I won't give up!" She promised, "Not on my friends, not on Etheria, not on myself." She vowed, struggling against the vines. "For the Honor of Grayskull!" She bellowed, raising the Sword of Protection over her head.

S4E12/E13: Destiny Part One and Part Two

Shadow Weaver

She was in a race against Glimmer, now. All of her months of pandering to the young Queen. Seeking to entrench herself as a trusted advisor, by teaching her magic, mentoring her... Showing her what true power was and how to wield it effectively! Trying to mold her into the Queen, Etheria needed…control her. Guide her, to be decisive in her decisions and uncompromising with her order's. Had just blown up in her face! By the Queen's desperate fears and impulsive nature.

If Scorpia connected with her Rune Stone before she invoked the spell of Sanctuary…then all was lost. All her decades of research, into the First Ones, into Rune Stones, the mad mage…Gorta and his forbidden spells. Her years of spell work to Master the Dark Sorcerer's spells. To decipher the secrets that lay hidden within Etheria….within Mystacor.

If Scorpia connected to the Black Garnet. All of her efforts would become useless, all her sacrifices made pointless. She had devoted her entire life to destroying the Nameless One. She couldn't lose her only chance at retribution…she couldn't fail now…

The old sorceress spirited down the narrow corridor of flames, having snuck into Mystacor once more. Retreating quickly down into the hidden catacombs beneath the floating Island. Disarming protection spells as she delved, deeper. Heading along well memorized paths towards a hidden chamber in the very bowels of the island. To the artificial Nexus point…the First Ones had erected. That would allow her to anchor herself to the planet…as she reached out to draw magic from the twelve sources themselves.

Out of breath and heaving for air, she never slowed as she reached the dim, gloomy room that housed the ancient crystal of Arxia. Her slippered feet struck the metal floor smartly as she headed unerringly towards the three glowing white crystal pillars in the center. Mounting the steps of the dais, she refused to give into her own fears. Keeping her mind focused and her emotions under control. As she quickly set to etching the spell within the middle of the crystals.

The ghostly hue of the pillars glow, falling upon her. As she pulls the shards of Rune Stones and other crystals she had spent a lifetime collecting, out of her velvet bag. Crushing them in her hand, one by one before using the dust to etch an intricate glyph upon the floor. All the while, murmuring the incantation of Sanctuary. That Gorta had written in his own blood in his forbidden spell book.

"Elidor, Jewel of the Sky.

High King of the Celestial Court.

The Light that pierces all darkness."

Shadow Weaver crushed the shard of the Moonstone in her hand. Allowing the dust to fall from her enclosed fist as she drew the first glyph. Swallowing her fears and doubts that the spell may not work. That she might be drawing her own death sentence if the deep magic backfired yet again.

She stared down at the fire agate shard in her hand, debating reciting the invocation of Adarion. As she was unable to complete the forbidden spell without a shard of the Sun Stone, that no longer existed. With the Guardian of Fire dead and the Sunna pretty much extinct…Catra predictably had no connection to the element. She had always been useless…in that regard.

With the planet in Despondo's she had no way to even gather that magic from the Source anyway. Even with the use of an alternate crystal that was capable of harmonizing with the fire element. Since Adarion did not get pulled into this shadow Dimension. What was left of fire magic, was barely a whisper upon Etheria now. As the First Ones artifact had absorbed every trace of it from Etheria. With a growl of frustration and acceptance of the risks she was taking, she crushed the Fire Agate and began the glyph to Adarion.

"Adarion, Guiding Star of Etheria.

Champion of the Celestial Court.

The Eternal Flame that purifies all."

She had hope, she had faith that she was strong enough, committed enough to her own fate, that her intentions were pure enough. To will the power she needed from what remained upon Etheria. To finally finish what she had started…she had to succeed…she didn't have a choice.

" **Sato.. Hunter of the Heaven's.**

Keeper of the Celestial Seal

The Binding that holds for Eternity."

Shadow Weaver continued to chant the spell **.** Substituting the Rune Stones that no longer existed with what she hoped would be a harmonizing crystal to that magic. Moving through each moon and runestone shard. Steadily and with great precision, drawing a

massive, highly complicated twelve point glyph between the three pillars.

Light Hope

The ancient planetary facilitator stood at the edge of the holographic precipice. Deep within the bowels of the First Ones beacon, known since the beginning as the Crystal Castle. She did not have access to information, as to why it was called that, only that this place was to train She-Ra and it was her responsibility to make sure the weapon was ready to fire when the planet was balanced.

So many secrets were hidden away from her, behind firewalls and encryption protocols. She never questioned why, never sought to disobey her programming. She had remained loyal to her programming for over a thousand years and soon, soon her purpose would be fulfilled.

The command room was vast, stretching out above and below as if this platform floated upon some dusk colored void, full of stars. Command screens hovered in the air on either side of her. Monitoring her connection to the Heart, to the Watch Tower and to the Super Computer. Before her was a glowing representation of the five Rune Stones connecting to the Planet's core.

As she raised her arms above her head, pushing the last piece into place. Five glowing symbols of the Runestones, connected to the central core of the planet..to the Heart. Floated just above her head, as she raised her arms and directed a golden icon of a sword into place. Above them all.

The sound of boot's echoing down the bridge towards the platform.

"Light Hope!" She-Ra called to her, a forced calm in her voice. Yet her glowing blue eyes were full of fear. "Please don't do this." She pleaded.

(You don't have a choice…you were chosen…) Light Hope's words echoed in her mind like a vice grip slowly squeezing away her free will.

"Good you are here." Light Hope turned, her expression blank. "Now we can begin. After a thousand years, my programming will be fullided. The Heart of Etheria will be unleashed against the First Ones enemies."

(* A low, malicious laughter echoed in the depths of her programming. *)

Everything was in its place, after a thousand years. She would complete her intended purpose…the will of the First Ones would finally be set free upon the universe.

First Ones glyphs scrawled over the blade of Protection, igniting with the command protocols as the sword began siphoning the magic from the Tesseract hidden in the core of the planet. She-Ra was the key, the princess of power. She would be forced to channel that magic and fire it…destroying the entire universe.

(A delighted, malicious tremble of anticipation swelled within LIght Hopes code.)

"No!" She-Ra exclaimed in terror, as her arm moved against her will. Raising the sword high over her head.

(You don't get to refuse…) Entrapta's voice echoed in Adora's mind like a scythe, sealing their doom. It was happening…she was losing control…she was becoming their weapon.

"There are no First Ones any more." Adora grasped the hilt with both hands, forcing the sword down. Even with She-Ra incredible strength, she felt her muscles straining. "Whatever war they were fighting, it's long over." She grunted in pain, stubbornly refusing to allow the sword to force her arms upward.

"The First Ones will rise again. You are a descendant of their mighty empire." Light Hope confronted her, an arm raised and her hand outstretched. Commanding the sword to raise, to force She-Ra to comply. As her hologram glitched.

[No….I won't allow you to do this…I locked this corruption away a thousand years ago…I can do it again!]

"That is why I used all my strength to reach across the entire universe to find you and bring you here." Light Hope revealed, drawing more power, as the command protocols began to crawl over She-Ra's arms.

(An intoxicating desire for oblivion overwhelming her code.)

Adora was confused…When Mara stranded them in Despondo's she had cut off their ability to create portals. How did Light Hope manage to do that, without ripping the fabric of reality like Catra did? It wasn't possible.

"You told me Hordak was the one who brought me through the portal." Adora was startled, her focus shattered for all of a second. As her arm's lurched upward, she locked her arms and forced them back down. Glaring heatedly at Light Hope.

"It was you all along, all of this is because of you! " Adora raged, at the impassive hologram. Her blood was boiling, rushing through her limbs like lava, seeking to obey the sword's pull to raise it above her head. Adora clenched her teeth and bared down with a growl. Refusing to allow the sword to take control of She-Ra. She released a furious scream, using all her strength to fight against the invisible force compelling her to raise the sword. Instead she slammed the blade down into the platform. Embedding the tip deep into the platform, locking it down for a time so she could catch her breath. Kneeling on the glowing holographic surface, with First Ones glyphs now covering every inch of her body. Her skin was humming, the command protocol's branding her flesh. A new agony adding to the already overwhelming pain she was in.

She-Ra slowly raised her head and glared defiantly at Light Hope. She would never be her weapon!

"This is your intended function. You will bring the first ones to glory. It is what you are born to do." Light Hope instructed.

[I will stop you…. You can't do this…the Heart is unstable…it's not completely balanced…if you unleashed it here in this dark dimension you will tear a hole in the fabric of reality…]

(Exhilaration…and smug satisfaction courses threw her code.)

"No, I won't!" Adora promised, vehemently. Even if her voice sounded scared and desperate. Her whole body was burning and it was a struggle to keep the blade embedded into the floor. As her arms were beginning to shiver under the exertion, her muscles aching to obey the sword. The burning of the glyphs on her skin increased as the command protocol's intensified their efforts to commandeer her body. She could smell her flesh beginning to immolate.

It was terrifying…but she was ready to sacrifice herself to save Etheria. So she focused on the pounding of her heart in her ears. It grounded her, to know that she was still alive…still fighting.

"The Heart of Etheria has been activated. You will be the one to fire it! There is no stopping it now." Light Hope advised, her tone commanding and laced with a finality that her will will be obeyed.

She-Ra groaned in pain, as the glyphs finally crawled over her face. Screaming in overwhelming agony, as she denied the sword from lifting. Every muscle in her body was on fire! The pain of denying the sword was becoming unbearable. But she wouldn't give in…she would endure this suffering…she would prevail.

She could smell her flesh cooking from the inside out…her body trying to rip itself apart…

So much pain…breathe…just breathe…

A swirling vortex of magic, formed high above. Cascading down upon her, in a maelstrom of raw, unfiltered magic. She was hunched in agony over the hilt of her sword. Her breathing was ragged as struggled to stay conscious.

When the magic struck the floor, cracking it and loosening the blade. Adora jolted with fright, then She-Ra rebounded her efforts to keep the blade down. Grunting and moaning, she could taste blood now, as she strained against the force compelling her to raise the sword. "It won't work…" she panted, " Mara stranded us in Despondos so you couldn't hurt anyone else." Adora professed, struggling against the unyielding pressure of the command protocol now tearing through her body.

"Mara…" Light Hope glitched…her voice changed…it was soft and sad.

"Mara's interference caused a significant delay. But no longer…with the planet balanced, portal capabilities are restored. Initiate planetary move…out of the Dimension of Despondos." Light Hope turned her attention back to the display, as she instructed the Inter-planetary command pathways to activate once again. With the Watch Tower repaired, she once again had access to the Super computer. The displays glowed brighter, flashing with the activation of the portal program once more.

(Dark malicious laughter, brimming with triumph echoed inside Light Hopes programming.)

As the full might of the magic siphoning from the princesses was unleashed upon She-Ra. The Heart of Etheria activated and it surged down enveloping her, the sword began to channel that power directly into She-Ra. Adora threw her head back, as her eyes turned white. Her mouth opened as a horrific scream of unbearable agony, ripped from her throat. Magic was now exploding from her eyes and mouth as her fragile body was unable to contain it all.

She was being ripped apart! Molecule by Molecule…only to be healed instantly by She-Ra's magic in some unending round of Destruction and Rebirth that is both terrifying and exhilarating to experience.

"The Heart is primed and ready. Commencing Activation." Light Hope commanded. As Adora knelt behind her. Her screams of suffering, falling on deaf ears as Light Hope was compelled to complete her programming.

It took a few moments to regain her control, as the magic had been so overwhelmingly painful to absorb. But Adora was resilient and she was stubborn. She would never allow the weapon to fire. With all her strength she closed her eyes, gritted her teeth and pushed the magic down. The glyphs faded…

"Look at all these stars.." She ground out, reeling from the pain. "These worlds, they will all be destroyed. " She pleaded, "Mara sacrificed her life to stop this from happening."

"Mara…Mara would not want me to…" The True Light Hope, surged if briefly to life inside the corrupted programming.

"Mara was a traitor, she turned against her people." The corrupted program responded, pushing her consciousness down once more.

"Mara was your friend " Adora was struggling to keep the magic contained. The raging torrent slammed against her mind and her body, seeking to exploit any weakness to leach out. Yearning to be released, to break out of the metaphysical fortifications she had erected.

It hurt so much to keep it inside…

" She knew you were more than just a program and so do I!" Adora beseeched her to be strong, to overcome her programming. Groaning and whimpering, as she fought against the surging magic, fought against the command protocol from the Sword that was punishing her for disobeying. "You can stop this. " Adora panted out between shallow breaths, as her bones now felt like they were breaking under the strain of keeping the sword down. Her insides twisting and liquefying from containing the magic inside herself.

"I am not as strong as Mara. I can not change my programming." The true Light Hope sighed, bowing her head in defeat. As her hologram glitched once more.

"This is our destiny. " Light Hope waved her arm towards the sword. Enforcing the Nameless One's will upon the Rune Stone. It glowed red as the fury of Despara's magic ignited within

the stone. That the Nameless had absorbed and corrupted, a thousand years ago. Thanks to Senator Keldor's ambition to shackle the Dark Goddess's essence into the Disc of Destruction, by trying to weaken her with a shard from the Crystal of Kaydak. Down in the depths of the Beast Island Laboratory, which had only backfired. Causing him to be corrupted by the Nameless One and the entire lab to be consumed by the rage virus he had just created. Unfortunately, Light Hope had been corrupted as well. When she had hacked into the Lab's system's to get Mara and her strike team inside to destroy Omega Prime. Which had set all of this into motion…over a thousand years ago.

She-Ra snapped her eyes open for a second as the Sword began to rise, the power rippling from the stone was too strong…She had to increase her efforts to keep it down. Grunting and clenching her biceps. "No! This is not my destiny!" Adora shouted defiantly, urging the blade down.

Her bones were bending…

"You will comply." Light Hope raised her hand, forcing She-Ra to raise the sword.

A desperate, terrified scream tore out of Adora as she fought against the sword.

Her bones were breaking…
NO…no,no,no…" Adora stuttered, as her arm began to rise.

Her muscles and tendons ripping asunder as she fought against the sword's command. Refusing to comply, refusing to give up. As the violent strength of the energies that crackled and swirled around her increased at an exponential rate. It soon became insurmountable. As the stone once blood red began to darken with the power of the Nameless One.

The force of the swords command protocols coursing through her blood was too strong, the magic a raging torrent of power she

was inevitably weakening against. It took just a second of doubt, a second of weakness for her to be overpowered and with a desperate cry the sword raised.

"It is time." Light Hope nodded, as the ribbon's of elemental magic of the Heart surged into the Rune Stone, with the last of the Princess's magic drained out of them.

"I won't be controlled." Adora glared defiantly at Light Hope. Her eyes flared and then began glowing with an inner power. One beyond the Nameless One's reach.

"I am not a piece of their machine. " Adora ground out through clenched teeth, tensing her arms…preparing for her next gambit to stop the annihilation of the entire Universe.

"I am not a weapon and I am going to end this now!" Adora declared, fortified by her own inner power, forcing the hilt down…pulling the sword away from firing the magic. It was taking all that she had to hold it back. Her arms were shivering, bones cracking, legs quaking with the amount of exertion She-Ra needed to hold the blade steady.

She would never allow that sword to fire…

It was her unyielding spirit keeping that weapon down.

"No…stop…" Light Hope gasped in horror.

(Sudden fear erupted deep inside her corrupted programing)

She-Ra screamed, a defiant roar that rippled through the very fabric of reality itself. Never allowing the sword even

an inch to raise up. The Magic in the Rune stone was overloading. Radiant streams of energy flaring and then exploding forth. A star going supernova overwhelmed the chamber.

"Don't…" Light Hope stuttered

(A horrified howl of fury echoed in her code)

"Do it…" The true Light Hope breathed in relief.

Star's began to fall from the heaven's around them. Streaking down like a prism curtain falling, from the endless void.

"Do it…" The Light Hope urged softly.

'Don't.." Light Hope pleaded.

(Desperation and panic sweeping through her code, in some vain attempt to regain control)

As all the sweet moments of her friendship with Mara cascaded over her core memory. No matter how many times, the corrupted program had commanded Light Hope to delete that data. It remained…the Love…the loyalty and the devotion cleansing away the dark corruption. Breaking its hold over her, after a thousand years, Light Hope was finally able to seal away the corruption behind another firewall. She slowly lowered her hand, recalling the command protocol and releasing She-Ra from the Sword's influence.

“Do it…” Light Hope begged…accepting her fate.

She-Ra shouted in triumph, the instant she was free. Having only a split second to make a decision. She spun the blade down, slamming its tip into the floor at an angle, with all the strength she had. The crystal blade cracked on impact then exploded, the magical blast was intense and blinding. Turning the entire chamber into a world of white. The deafening hum of the sword's destruction, echoed into the void with a finality. That the First Ones last weapon against Prime was now gone forever.

Adora was reeling upon the platform, having crumpled to her knees at the end. Amazed that she had survived. Ears ringing, panting and hissing in unbelievable pain. Her head hurt, the piercing throb behind her eyes was intense. Making her dizzy and nauseous. Rubbing her forehead to try and clear her head.

Everything hurt….everything ached with such a deep bone numbing throb. She was reluctant to move.

“Adora…” Light Hope placed a hand tenderly on her shoulder, softly urging her to open her eyes.

Adora blinked, finding what remained of the hologram kneeling before her as she sat within the dark void the chamber had become. She was glitching badly, her form buzzing and shifting erratically.

“Thank you…” Light Hope whispered with a grateful smile, as she vanished forever.

Adora, sniffled and bowed her head as guilt and remorse washed over her. Left to sit in that darkness and absorb what she had done. Staring down at the shattered Sword of Protection…wondering if she had made the right

choice, if there might have been another way….how was she going to live without She-Ra? How could she protect everyone now?

Shadow Weaver

Hours later, she would find herself slowly coming around after falling unconscious. A piercing throb pounding behind her eyes, her mind sluggish. Unable to remember clearly what had happened at first. Left writhing in the aftermath of the failed spell of Sanctuary. Screaming in unimaginable pain. As the unfinished spell had ripped through her frail body. As she had been unable to connect to the Black Garnet, unable to thread all the elements to create the seal properly. Which caused a feedback loop of the magic she had managed to harness into the seal. To surge back upon her, in a devastating wave of untamed magic. Her throat was raw, her now weak and decaying body burning as if her insides had just been shredded. The agony this time was far worse then when the Spell of Obtainment devoured her. She wished for death, just to be free of the pain.

But the Nameless One would never allow her to die. Gorta's parasitic essence, as always sustained her, redirecting the threads of magic she had managed to absorb from the Rune Stone Shards to keep her alive. Leaving her wretched undead corpse to slowly heal over the course of several days. As she lay stunned and in agony upon the platform. The Crystal of Arxia looming over her, their pure white glow taunting her in the gloomy, crypt like silence. Her once eviscerated mind cleared. Enough for her to stumble out of the Fail Safe chamber and navigate through the catacombs without setting off any traps. To return, a failure to the rebellions side and like slow torture be reduced to some inconsequential nothing among their ranks. Her pleas and advice fell on deaf ears once more. Loathed and shunned by Adora, by

Micah and left to wallow in her resentments and bitterness once again.

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Catra

In the days that followed, Glimmer and her abduction from the Fright Zone. She had retreated into the obscurity of the Velvet Gloves, endless corridors. Wandering aimlessly.

Becoming little more than a ghost, haunting these, vaulted, sterile halls. She shuffled at a slow, steady pace.

As time became meaningless.

Scratching her claws down the smooth metal, a small act of destruction. Of rebellion, of retaliation against Prime. She was angry and she was scared. That she was once again at the mercy of yet another Tyrant, metaphorically enslaved to another military regime.

So once again, survival…it was all that mattered.

As she was reduced to nothing yet again and having to fight for her place once more in the ranks of this new Horde. To prove to Prime that she was useful.

That she was worth keeping around…

Knowing that if she failed…she would be disposed of.

Lost and adrift, in her memories…slowly being crushed by the guilt over how terribly she had treated Adora, Entrapta…Scorpia. Her gaze dull and clouded with unspeakable grief…a grim, solitary thought spinning round and round. Plaguing her like an omen.

She had lost everything…

She had been ready to let Glimmer finish her…

Never had she ever been so defeated, so miserable, so utterly broken that death was appealing…

But she was alone now.

Alone…

She didn’t matter…

Nothing mattered...

She had never in her life been so scared…

The weight of what she had done to the people of Etheria, how meaningless it all was…

It ate at her..

Her bad choices…her destructive rage…her heartache…

So much guilt…

So much regret…

She felt so heavy…

Catra reluctantly pulled her hand away from the wall. Mutely acknowledging the long jagged scar she had put down the corridor. Curling her fingers into a fist and pressing her hand against her chest. It had been a week perhaps more, since she had been taken. The ache in her chest had never eased… mismatched eyes shimmering with unshed tears. That pooled in the corner of her eyes, refusing to fall. She cast her mournful gaze down in shame.

She was so tired…light headed…her mind and body had been under stress for far too long. Her heart had never stopped beating frantically against her ribcage. Far too many, life threatening confrontations and grim revelations had assaulted her. Leaving her pulse pounding in her ears and her body vibrating with fear and adrenaline. That she had yet to purge. Locked in her own dark spiral, tortured by recent events. She needed to find a safe place to calm down and recalculate her future. But this place was so open, there was nowhere for her hide!

She was trapped on this ship. Her future is just as uncertain as it was three years ago. Yet this time she lacked the ambition to bite and claw her way up the chain of command.

She just didn't care anymore…

Horde Prime was far scarier and more dangerous than Hordak ever was. After what happened to Hordak in the throne room just after being abducted.

She was terrified of Prime, of what he was capable of doing. She could have stayed hidden…behind the broken debris that had been teleported up with them from the base. But she would have been found eventually. She had no options and no means of escape. So she went to Glimmer's rescue. Who had been stunned mute by everything that had happened. Still reeling no doubt from her magic being drained and nearly dying…then being teleported off planet in the next breath. Left trembling and numbed by the trauma of it all. The shell shocked Queen could only stand and stare in both awe and terror. When confronted by the creepy, seven foot frame of Horde Prime. Now towering over her, after his cruel display of power by punishing Hordak for daring to give himself a name, a purpose that was not dictated by him. To think that he was equal…to his creator.

Glimmer was so out of her depth, naive to think Prime thought of her as an equal just because she was royalty. Professing that he only desired peace and order. The trembling Queen, pathetically, asking if he would just leave Etheria alone. Which only made him

laugh mirthlessly, as he then quickly corrected her. Stating that Hordak's actions were an embarrassment and now he had no choice but to obliterate Etheria and her.

Catra was used to swallowing her fear and standing up to tyrants. So she pushed in front of the Queen, placing herself in Prime's way. Explaining that Etheria was an ancient super weapon and Glimmer was a part of it. Making Glimmer invaluable and herself useful in return. That he would need her to understand how to use it. Offering her allegiance to him…

Now she felt so empty…in every way…

Subtle acts of defiance were needed to soothe the fear and give her at least a little bit of power, of control. So she found herself drawn towards Glimmer's cell.

With a bitter, annoyed moan, at her own weakness. She turned, heading in the direction of the cells. Where Glimmer was being kept…the closer she got to the cells. The more her throat clenched and swallowing hurt. It felt like shards of glass slicing her insides.

She felt so pathetic…for seeking out her enemy for companionship. Peeking around the corner of an intersection, just before the corridor full of cells. She watched Glimmer pacing behind the forcefield. She looked so scared, biting her lower lip and holding herself. In a very similar manner, Catra did when she was extremely scared and upset. The emotional connection she felt towards the Queen was startling. Suddenly the magicat couldn't breathe…her chest felt too tight…she couldn't do it…she just wasn't ready to talk to her.

What would it solve anyway…Glimmer hated her.

Casting her eyes down but ear's up and alert to her surroundings. She turned on her heel and retreated swiftly back into the bowels of Horde Primes flagship.

As both her mind and her body began to wander again.

What did she truly want?

She had nothing but time now to contemplate that question.

Chapter End Notes

If you want more details about what happened to Light Hope and Shadow Weaver. Go read Kingdom of Light and Shadow, in my main fic Tapestry of Time.
Ok, Bye. Going to go work on Kingdom of Secrets now.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!